Meanwhile, the news of the debacle in Bomdila was sending shock waves through the highest levels in the government. Prime Minister Nehru, stunned by the news, asked to meet General Thorat who, after his retirement, was living in Kolhapur near Poona. The former Eastern Army Commander received the news with some trepidation, for he had parted company with the prime minister under strained circumstances. Thorat quickly dug out two sets of papers in preparation for the meeting: an assessment of the Chinese threat that he had prepared in November 1959 and Exercise Lal Qila which had been held on 17 March 1960 and had been attended by all army commanders and principal staff officers in Army HQ —which included Lieutenant Generals Thapar, Kaul and Sen.

The headlines in the morning newspapers announced the fall of Se-la and Bomdila. General Thapar had briefed the prime minister on the situation in NEFA the previous evening and had asked that his resignation be accepted. He had also recommended that Assam be evacuated immediately.

Flying to Delhi in a special IAF aircraft early in the morning, Thorat was driven straight from Palam to South Block. When he entered the prime minister's office, Thorat saw a haggard looking Nehru sitting at his desk with a vacant look on his face: 'It was indeed a pathetic sight. He was holding an unlit cigarette in one hand and a pair of scissors in the other with which he was cutting the cigarette into small pieces. With clouded eyes he looked up and signalled me to take a seat.'

After a brief silence, Nehru looked up and said: 'Thorat, how could this have happened? You were in Eastern Command; did you have any inkling of the disaster?'

'Yes, sir,' said Thorat, 'the possibility had occurred to us in Eastern Command and the Ministry was warned.'

Nehru said: 'Of course I knew that we were having trouble with the Chinese over some border incidents, but I never thought it would come to this.'

'Sir, the Army had foreseen this possibility and given a warning,' said Thorat.

'When?' asked Nehru sharply.

Thorat said he had signed the note on 8 October 1959 and sent it to General Thimayya who in turn had marked it to the defence minister. 'It was never shown to me,' Nehru snapped after which he went through